India’s National Security Council comprises the prime minister, the national security adviser, the external affairs minister, the defence minister, the finance minister and the vice chairman of the NITI Aayog (earlier the deputy chairman of the planning commission). The composition of the National Security Council and the Cabinet Committee on Security is the same, except for the addition of the national security adviser and vice chairman of the NITI Aayog. It is argued that the Cabinet Committee on Security always has three or four issues to deal with and has to make quick decisions. It does not have time for elaborate presentations or brainstorming on any issue. The National Security Council, on the other hand, is designed to discuss one issue at a time in greater detail. In practice, however, the National Security Council meets infrequently, often only once or twice a year, and spends most of its time on dealing with strategic issues tied to nuclear command and control.

Organizationally, the National Security Council comprises the Strategic Policy Group (SPG), the National Security Advisory Board (NSAB) and a secretariat represented by the Joint Intelligence Committee (JIC). The deputy national security adviser heads the National Security Council Secretariat. The Joint Intelligence Committee (JIC), originally set up in 1948, analyses intelligence data from all intelligence agencies, domestic and foreign, civilian as well as military. It was originally headed by an MEA officer and rarely fulfilled its role of collecting, coordinating, processing and evaluating intelligence inputs and reports from all ministries. It was reconstituted in 1965 with officers both civilian and uniformed military. When the National Security Council system was set up, along with the appointment of a national security adviser, the Joint Intelligence Committee was included within it.

India’s National Security Council has the advantage of being able to tap into the National Security Advisory Board as an in-house think tank. The Indian system has, in the past, failed to use local think tanks for inputs, and